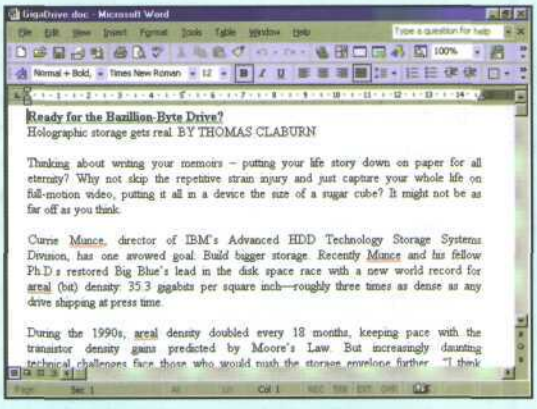
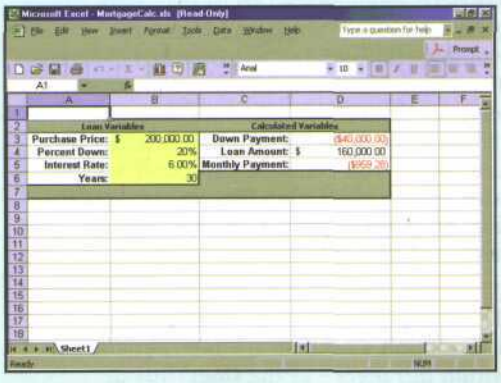
UNIT 8

Applications Programs

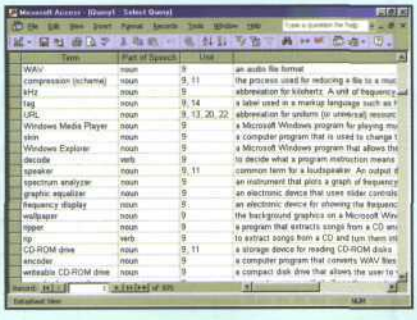
STARTER 1 Identify these applications programs.



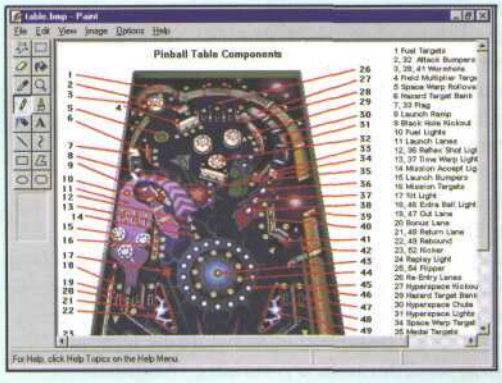
a



b



c



d

e

Fig 1
Screen displays

2 Conduct a survey to find out who in your class:

1 can name a spreadsheet program
2 has used a spreadsheet
3 can name a database program
4 has used a database
5 knows how to insert graphics into a document
6 can name a wordprocessing program
7 can centre a line of text
8 can disable the autocorrect

3 Study this diagram of a medical centre. Which applications programs will be used by the following?

1 Reception
2 Practice Manager
3 Doctors

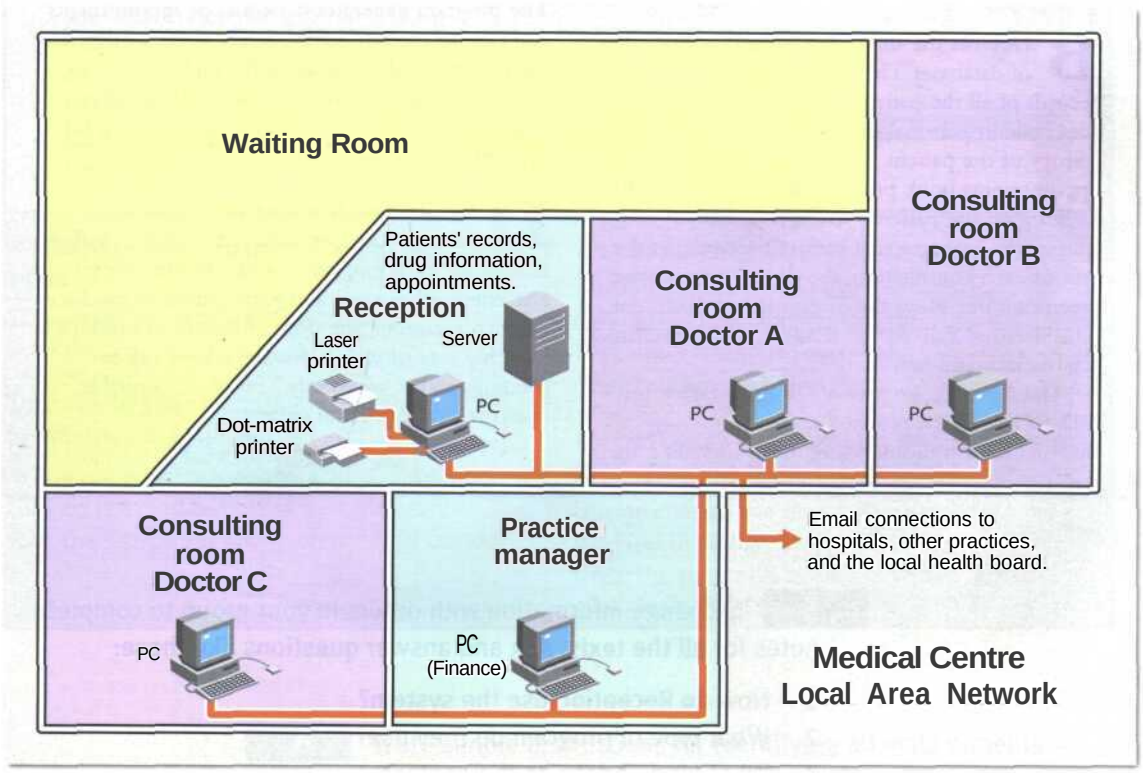


Fig 2
Medical centre LAN

READING **4** Work in groups. Read paragraph A and additional paragraphs selected by your teacher. Complete this note-taking frame for each text you read.

	B	C	D
Users			
Use			
Program types			
Data input			
Output			

A The system consists of 5 networked PCs, one in each of the consulting rooms, one in the Practice Manager s office and the other in Reception alongside the file server. (Each PC has its own laser printer.) There is also a dot-matrix printer in Reception for prescriptions as these are printed on special paper. All users have access to Microsoft Office.

B Doctors use the system to access a number of databases. The most important holds the records of all the patients in the practice. These files contain personal details and the medical history of the patient. The doctor can call up the appointments book prior to the consultation. By clicking on the patient's name, they have immediate access to that patient's records. At the end of each consultation, the doctor enters brief case notes including the diagnosis and treatment. This database can also be used to produce statistics for research and reports.

Doctors can also access a drugs database on CD-ROM which provides prescribing information on thousands of drugs including their suitability for different categories of patients. This is updated every month. Another database is a conditions dictionary which provides information on a wide range of problems.

C Reception staff use specially tailored software developed from a database to enter all appointment dates and times for each doctor. The program generates daily lists of appointments and can be accessed by the doctors. Reception use the patient database to identify children and old people who are due to have vaccinations. They then use mailmerging to create letters asking for appointments to be made.

D The Practice Manager uses a payroll package based on a spreadsheet to calculate salaries for each employee of the health centre. She enters all income and expenditure to produce practice accounts. She uses a database to produce a monthly rota of which doctors are on call in evenings and at weekends. This rota is available over the network to all users.

5 Exchange information with others in your group to complete notes for all the texts. Ask and answer questions like these:

1 How do Reception use the system?
2 What type of program do they use?
3 What kind of data do they enter?
4 What is the output from the program?

LANGUAGE WORK Instructions/complex instructions

Study this extract from an instruction manual for software for doctors in a health centre.

PATIENT BROWSER

Patient Browser allows you to find specific patients and open their records. It also allows you to identify different categories of patients.

Maximise, minimise, and close buttons

Click here to display or remove search criteria

Title Bar

Menu Bar

Tool Bar

1 To find patients, first click on the appropriate tab (Personal, Address or Registration).

2 Enter the search criteria. A combination of tabs may be used (e.g. enter a surname under the Personal tab and select a doctor in the Registration tab).

3 Select the Defaults button if you wish to clear the criteria boxes of any existing entries, or to search for all patients, but the list may be a long one.

4 Start the search by clicking on the Find button.

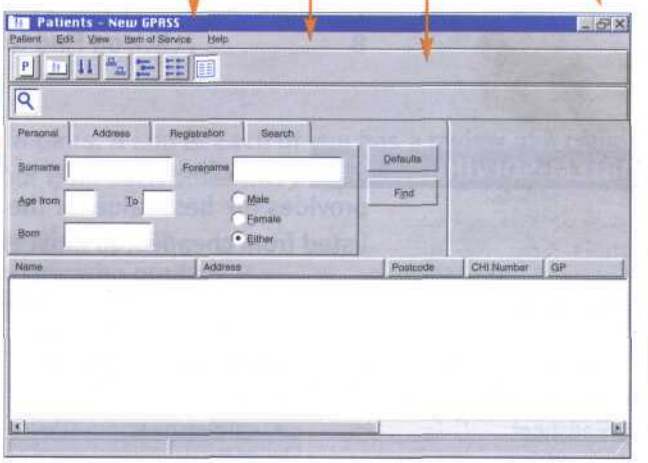


Fig 3
GPASS

We make simple instructions using the infinitive:

Click on the appropriate tab.
Enter the search criteria.

We can add an explanation using the to-infinitive or *by + -ing:*

To find patients, click on the appropriate tab.
Click on the Find button *to start* the search.
Start the search *by clicking* on the Find button.

We can put the instructions in order using sequence words:

First click on the appropriate tab.
Then enter the selection criteria.
Finally click on the Find button.

We can link two instructions and emphasise their order like this:

Having entered the selection criteria, click on the Find button.
Once the selection criteria *have been entered,* click on the Find button.

6 Write simple instructions for identifying all male patients called Smith in the 16 to 50 age group registered with Doctors Warner and Roberts.

7 Complete the gaps in these instructions for finding the records of all members of the Green family living in postcode WX14 3PH and registered with any doctor in the practice.

1 First enter the search criteria by.....
2 To....., enter Green in the Surname box.
3 Ensure both male and female members of the family are found by ..... .
4 .....select the Address tab.
5 Having....., enter the postcode.
6 .....choose the Registration tab.
7 Once.....select All doctors.
8 ....., click on Find to.....

PROBLEM-SOLVING 8 Study these versions of OfficeSuite and decide which version provides the best value for the following users. The versions are listed from cheapest to most expensive.

OfficeSuite Standard

- wordprocessor
- spreadsheet
- presentation program
- email
- PIM

OfficeSuite Small Business Edition

- wordprocessor
- spreadsheet
- DTP
- email
- PIM
- small business tools

OfficeSuite Professional

- wordprocessor
- spreadsheet
- database
- DTP
- presentation program
- email
- small business tools

OfficeSuite Premium

- wordprocessor
- spreadsheet
- database
- DTP
- presentation program
- email
- PIM
- small business tools
- website editor
- image editor

OfficeSuite Developer

- wordprocessor
- spreadsheet
- database
- DTP
- presentation program
- email
- PIM
- small business tools
- website editor
- image editor
- developer tools

1 A salesperson who wants to make presentations at conferences.
2 An administrative assistant who needs to write office correspondence and send and receive emails.
3 A programmer who wants to develop applications tailored to a company's needs.
4 A company wanting to produce its own in-house newsletter.
5 A company wishing to develop its own website.
6 A company which wants to analyse all its sales records.
7 A promotions person who wants to be able to edit complex graphics and incorporate them in brochures.
8 A company which wants to share documents on a local area network.

SPEAKING **9** Work in pairs, A and B. Each of you has a review of a computer game. Find out from each other this information:

1 The name of the game.
2 The company who produce it.
3 The platform on which it's played.
4 The bad points.
5 The good points.
6 The star rating.

Student A your game details are on page 185.
Student B your game details are on page 191.

WRITING **10** Work in groups. Decide which applications programs would be used and for what purpose, by the following:

1 a museum
2 publishers of a subscription-only magazine
3 police headquarters

11 Write your recommendations for one of the users in Task 10. Give reasons for each applications program you recommend.

SPECIALIST READING

A **Find the answers to these questions in the text below.**

1 How do you pay for the applications provided by an ASP?
   a no charge
   b charged according to use
   c single payment
2 What two main services does an ASP provide?
3 How does an ASP ensure that they have enough storage space for the changing needs of customers?
4 What types of applications are available from ASPs?
5 Why is it useful for a small business to be able to rent specialist tools from an ASP?
6 What is one of the best established areas of ASP use?

Application Service Providers

If your hard disk is packed to bursting point, the IT department is far too busy to fix your email problems, and your business can't afford to buy the tools that you'd like to develop the company website, then it's time to think about using an application service provider (ASP). Rather than installing software on each machine or server within your organisation, you rent applications from the ASP, which provides remote access to the software and manages the hardware required to run the applications.

There are a lot of advantages to this approach. The havoc caused by viruses makes the idea of outsourcing your email and office suite services an attractive option. It also gives you more flexibility - you pay for applications as and when you need them, rather than investing in a lot of costly software which you're then tied to for years. Not having to worry about upgrading to the latest version of your office suite or about battling with the complexities of managing an email system, leaves businesses with more time. Time to focus on what they do best.

However, there are some potential pitfalls. To use applications remotely requires a lot of bandwidth, which is only really available from a broadband connection or a leased line to the ASP itself. It is also important to ensure that the ASP will be able to provide a secure, reliable service which will be available whenever you need it.

Providing applications and storage space for vast numbers of users requires some powerful technology on the part of the ASP. This includes security controls and data storage as well as providing the physical links to customers. For

the most part, ASPs don't own the data centres that store the information. Instead, they lease space from data storage specialists. In this way, they can be confident of meeting customers' increasing storage requirements by buying more space as it's needed.

There's a wide variety of applications available for use via ASPs. Office suite applications and email services are two of the most generic applications available through ASPs. Large, complex business applications such as enterprise resource planning tools like SAP are another popular candidate for delivery through an ASP. Other business services, such as payroll and accounting systems are also available. This is particularly beneficial to small businesses which are likely to grow quickly and don't want to deal with the problems caused by outgrowing their existing system and having to move to a high-end package. ASPs also offer a means of using specialist tools that would otherwise prove prohibitively expensive. Small businesses have the opportunity to use such tools for short periods of time as and when they need them, rather than having to buy the software as a permanent investment.

One of the major barriers for small businesses which want to make a start in e-commerce is ensuring that they have sufficient resources to cope with sudden large increases in customers. This means not only having adequate storage for all your customers' details, but ensuring that you have the technology in place to handle stock levels, efficient delivery and large volumes of traffic. It's very rare for an e-commerce business to handle all of these elements by itself, making this one of the best-established areas of ASP use. Being able to respond rapidly to changes in the size of your customer base and the type of product that they want to order from your business, demands more flexibility than traditional software can provide.

[Adapted from 'ASP and you shall receive' by Maggie Williams, PC Direct Magazine, November 2000]

B **Re-read the text to find the answers to these questions.**

1 Note the advantages and disadvantages of using an ASP.

2 Match the items in Table A with the statements in Table B.

Table A

a Website
b ASP
c Virus
d Office suite
e Bandwidth
f Broadband
g Data centre
h SAP

Table B

i Set of standard programs used in an office
ii Facility for storing large amounts of information
iii Capacity of a network connection
iv High capacity Internet connection
v Self-replicating program
vi Common enterprise resource planning tool
vii Application service provider
viii Collection of related webpages

3 Using information from the text, mark the following as True or False:

a Software from an ASP must be installed locally on a user's computer.
b You need a high bandwidth connection to use an ASP service.
c ASPs usually use their own storage space for customers.
d Using an ASP gives you more flexibility.
e An e-commerce business usually provides all of the required technology itself.